

The Narrative Paintings of India's Jitwarpuri Women

Author(s): Jagdish J. Chavda

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During the 1960-61 monsoon season, Bihar state in eastern India experienced a serious drought resulting in a widespread scarcity of food. The state government launched relief projects to help the mainly illiterate population. These projects varied according to local customs and needs. The central idea, however, was to help people help themselves and enable them to become self-sufficient. Based on ideas from the Gandhian philosophy of promoting small village industries and total self-sufficiency, the Bihar government awarded Bombay-born artist Bhaskar Kulkarni a grant of Rs. 50,000 (about \$2800) to launch a relief enterprise.

In search of a suitable project, Kulkarni traveled to various regions. In Jitwarpur, a village southeast of the city of Madhubani, the artist observed wall reliefs of utmost beauty made from mixtures of cow dung and mud. Many a wall became a narrative relief depicting Hindu religious festivals and folklore. Recognizing the charm of these attempts, Kulkarni encouraged their creators, the village women, to execute their designs on paper. He used the grant funds to provide the women with commercial colors, ink brushes, and other art supplies. They later translated these images to cloth as well. Kulkarni showed the women's first designs at the government's Industrial Exhibition in New Delhi in 1962, where they sold for between Rs. 5 and 10, or between 35 and 70 cents.

The practical skill of Jitwarpuri women is known as Madhubani art because of the village's proximity to that city. Jitwarpur is a sleepy village of some 7000 people situated in Mithila district, a matriarchal enclave near the northern border of Bihar state and the Mahabharat range of the Nepalese Himalayas, which forms the border between India and Nepal. The streets are very narrow, usually ending in lanes flanked by tiny mud dwellings. A common wall often serves two adjoining dwellings. There is no train or bus service, and the village has an electrical connection for only a few hours each day. Thus, the Jitwarpuri women often work at night in light provided by kerosene lamps. The village, isolated from any major water source, relies on rains for its water supply. On the outskirts of Jitwarpur live the Harijani, the untouchables.

Madhubani art is an art of women only, and some 300 women in Jitwarpur practice the art. Although some young boys help their mothers, on reaching adolescence they join their fathers in cultivating the family plots. A visitor to the village would witness an afternoon gathering of women singing native songs while painting from memory various religious and folkloric themes. In Hindu society it is customary for girls to learn household chores—cooking, cleaning, and washing—at an early age. A six-year-old Jitwarpuri daughter not only learns these duties but also paints and helps care for younger siblings. Historical events recorded in precious Hindu religious texts such as the *Ramayana* and *Mahabha-rata* provide the form and

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By Jagdish J. Chavda

content for the Jitwarpuri women's narratives. Most of the village women are illiterate. However, these narratives are familiar to all Hindus and are part of the region's oral tradition.

The *Mahabha-rata* describes India as the land beyond the Indus River, with Hindus as its inhabitants.¹ After the Aryan migration from Iran around 2200 B.C., the caste structure among the nomadic inhabitants of the Indus Valley became well established. According to Hindu theology, four *varnas* (divisions) developed from the deity, the mother goddess. The Brahmins (priestly class) evolved from the mouth of the deity, while the Kshatriyas (warrior-nobility class) were supported by her arms. Her thighs supported the Vaishyas (business class), while the Sudras (lowest class) were born from the feet.

The Sudras were assigned the responsibility of serving the other three *varnas*. As a result of intermarriages, several subcastes have evolved. The Harijani belong to the Sudra *varna*.

From the Indus Valley, the Aryans migrated northeast into the prosperous ancient kingdom of Videha. History records that Videha was colonized by the Aryans under Chief Videgha Mathava some 4000 years ago. With the divine help of the Hindu fire god, Agni, Chief Mathava crossed the River Gandak into an area that now extends to the greater Jitwarpur district.

During the reign of King Mithi (c. 1000 B.C.), the area covering Bihar and southern Nepal was known as Mithila. King Mithi developed a new language, Mithili, which today is one of the regional dialects in the district.

As early as 3102 B.C., Mithila became a well-known art center; it has survived many wars and invasions, including that by the Pandava brothers described in the *Mahabha-rata*. The arts were also influenced by the great hero Prince Rama (Ramachandra) of Ayodhya, who affirmed the hand of Mithila's famous Princess Sita in marriage at the *darbar* (court) of her philosopher-father, King Janaka. According to the *Ramayana*, when Rama arrived at court, the king ordered his attendants to fetch the formidable bow to test whether Rama was worthy of the princess's hand. Four strong-shouldered attendants lifted the ancient bow and placed it before Rama. But Rama took hold of the great bow with such ease that when he strung and pulled it, all that was heard was the booming resonance of its shatter.² This story is depicted in a 15" x 11" pen-and-ink line drawing entitled *Lord Rama and the Bow* (1984) by Bacchow Devi, an artist in her mid-forties. Such a vast and rich history of some 5000 years can never be exhausted in the narrative content these Jitwarpuri women cull for their art.

Two distinct but overlapping styles of art are practiced by the women of the two distinct castes in the Jitwarpur village. The "spiritual" form is produced by the Brahmani and a few other high-caste women, the "secular" by the Harijani (untouchable) women. Both styles use religious or folkloric images and flat patterns of vibrant colors to inspire faith. There



Fig. 1. Savita Devi, Goddess Durga (1983), pen and ink, watercolor, handmade paper, 15" x 11".



Fig. 2. Lila Devi, Ardh-Narishvara (1984), pen and ink, watercolor, handmade paper, 15" x 11".



Fig. 3. Bhuvra Devi, Siva Linga (1983), pen and ink, watercolor, handmade paper, 15" x 11".

are no rules or hierarchies of images, and each woman creates according to her own inspiration. Each work is considered a form of personal prayer, perhaps in the same context as a Japanese *raigo* or the Hindu-Buddhist *mandala*. The artists believe that viewers should experience the same prayer that they were engrossed in while executing the art.

Brahmani women execute their art in a precise and formal manner. It is geometric and highly stylized. The women claim that the deity will sojourn within their artworks if they are created with full rites and sentiment. They indicate the signs and symbols of the deities, leaving their facial lines loosely defined. "Mankind lacks the strength and power to draw the precise face of any deity," one woman explained to me. Lord Siva, the destroyer, and the deity Durga figure prominently in their paintings. In some compositions a *lingam*, a phallic symbol used extensively in the cult worship of Siva, is placed in front of Durga. Six virgins dancing suggestively around Siva's *linga* indicate his presence. Sometimes female figures are shown bowing their heads in obedience to Siva. A notion of high energy superimposed around Siva's *linga* indicates the presence of the goddess Shakti. An ascetic Siva is shown in the position of a Yogin (one who practices Yoga). Among other representations, a flying parrot on a *yonis* (female aspect) symbolizes the *kama* (playful classification of men), while a mouse represents the esoteric Ganesa, master of the company of Siva.

Lord Visnu as a solar god is often represented by the sun. He is depicted as a type of hero in the form of Vasudeva, or as Narayana, a cosmic god in the form of the serpent Sesha. Also, Rama is often shown with or represented by an ax or a bow.

Well known among Jitwarpuri artists is Jagadamba Devi, a Brahmin now in her nineties. (All Bihari women have Devi, which means "the bright or shining one," for their second name. In Hinduism, Devi is the great mother goddess and consort of Lord Siva.) Jagadamba Devi was the first Jitwarpuri woman to experiment with handmade colors and materials. In 1963, using vegetable dyes, she began painting on paper, cloth, and small carpets made from palm leaves. A detail of a large straw carpet (inside front cover) shows the goddess Devi as mother of worship. (The family sits on this carpet during mid-day meals.)

The worship of the goddess Devi for nine days and nights during the Navaratri festival is an ancient tradition. It forms part of the Tantric ritual of homage to the Divine Self, or Brahman (the absolute principle).⁴ Devi is known and paid homage as a supreme deity under many names. As Uma, she is *sattvic* (the Great Mother); as Parvati, she is energy (a consort of Siva); as Durga, she is *ragasic* (active); and as Kali, she is *tamasic* (goddess of death). In this narrative rug painting, Jagadamba Devi depicts her as Kali, the four-armed black goddess of generation and destruction. Mouth open, red tongue thrust out, and wearing a garland of heads, she is surrounded by all those she dominates. The image is not just a magical fetish for worship but stands for a manifestation of the Supreme Being. According to her daughter, "Jagadamba Devi created the image from memory. It is her way of achieving identification with the deity."

In 1975 Jagadamba Devi was awarded the Indian civilian award Padma Shri in recognition of her pioneering talents and development of the Jitwarpuri style. She stopped painting in 1980, at age 88.

By tradition, Sita Devi, a Brahmin and at 70 the oldest Jitwarpuri painter, has been "elected" the spokeswoman-leader of the group. Both the Brahmin and Harijani women belong to the same group. Their artwork has somewhat broken down the caste system, and all the women receive equal-status memberships. Socially, however, the two castes remain segregated, and few intermarry. Further, both the Brahmini and Harijani are proud of their distinct styles and wish to preserve them.

In 1975 Sita Devi received the "Master Craftsman" award from then Indian President Shri. Fakhruddin Ali Ahmad, and in 1977 she too was awarded a Padma Shri. She has visited several foreign countries to demonstrate and lecture on Madhubani art. With the aid of a government grant, she and four assistants teach their skills to some 80 young Jitwarpuri girls. In 1978 Sita Devi was commissioned to create murals for the Bharatiya restaurant in New Delhi's famous Akbar Hotel. She spent almost a year on the project, which stands as a permanent tribute to her skills and endeavors in promoting Madhubani art.

Goddess Durga, through whom the energy of action operates, is highly venerated in this region. She is often painted on

walls near a building's entranceway. In *Goddess Durga* (1983; Fig. 1) Savita Devi shows Durga riding a lion—a divine form that she assumed to destroy demons. In Tantric literature, flagrant emotional reactions like anger, arrogance, greed, hatred, and violence are “demons.” These demons were subdued by the goddess Durga when they waged war against her. Some were even beheaded, as seen in her two lower hands. Explains Savita Devi of her work, “By developing patience and endurance, one is worshipping the goddess as she tests each and every one of us.”

According to “Siv Purana” (a versified text devoted to the cult of Siva) literature, Lord Siva assumed a half-male/half-female *swarup* (aspect). The female expression represents the Beautiful One, the Creator and giver of fertility. This difficult posture is captured in the artwork of Lila Devi, a Brahmin in her early forties. In *Ardh-Narishvara* (Male-Female) (1984; Fig. 2), she shows the male form, Siva, on the left in dark color with the three horizontal lines in the forehead and the *lingam* on his head. The *lingam* with three horizontal lines is symbolic of the Sivite faith of Hinduism. The female *swarup* is adorned with a geometrically patterned flowing red sari.

Bhuva Devi's *Siva Linga* (1983; Fig. 3) shows the *lingam* symbol repeated five times. Lord Siva as Mahesha (Supreme Deity) assumed all functions of the Trinity—destroyer, preserver, and creator. He also ruled the five elements of the universe—ether, fire, water, earth, and sky. Siva's *lingam* is always guarded by serpents, mostly cobras. Balanced on either side of the Siva representation are two devotional young maidens. Bhuva Devi's work places her somewhere between the complex patterning of the Brahmani and the more primitive imagery of the Harijani.

The Harijani women's art is more earthly than that of the Brahmani. Secular figures of cows, elephants, goats, and children are depicted in imaginative proportions, as in Ram Pari Devi's delightful *Festival* (1984; Fig. 4). Popular figures from Indian folklore such as elephants with long trunks, short legs, and long tails add charm to their inventions. Faces with childlike features are often placed on adult body frames. This type of loosely painted figure is also found scattered amidst the cow-dung smears on the inner walls of the Harijani thatched huts. More complex in its patterning but utilizing the same deep reds, golds, and blacks is *Chandra Ma* (1984; Fig. 5), by Harijani artist Janaki Devi. The celestial origin of the Chandra (Moon) is personified in a childlike maiden. Two Sivite guardians attend her.

Red and green, the sacred colors of Hinduism, predominate in all Madhubani art. By now all the women have progressed beyond the commercial products given to them by Kulkarni almost 30 years ago and are experimenting with their own pigments. They make black from soot and lamp black. Flowers with high iron content such as those from plants with thorns are crushed and mixed with flaxseed oil to obtain bright colors. Goat milk or plant enzymes are used as drying agents for colors

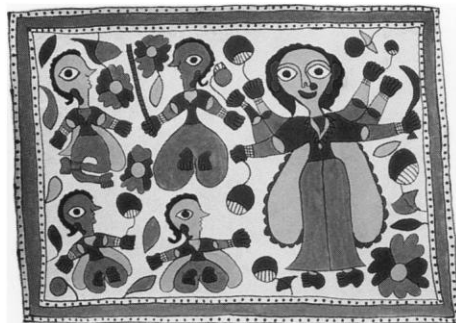


Fig. 4. Ram Pari Devi, *Festival* (1984), pen and ink, watercolor, paper, 10" x 12".



Fig. 5. Janaki Devi, *Chandra Ma* (1984), pen and ink, handmade colors on paper, 10" x 12".

used on cloth. The earth tones are made from the soil around Jitwarpur. Thin twigs from Babul or other trees of the Acacia stem are tied with threads to form brushes. Gum tapped from the Babul tree is also used to adhere the pigments to cloth. The poisonous creeper plant that provides bright yellows and the Indigo plant from which come blues and violets are also native to the region.

The success of Jitwarpuri women has brought some foreign visitors to their remote village and has stimulated women in surrounding areas to practice art. In nearby Rante, some 35 women have begun to emulate the Madhubani style. The state government of Bihar has set up an emporium in Bombay to market Madhubani art. The National Handicraft Center in New Delhi has had several exhibitions to promote Madhubani art, and the work is on display in the homes of the Indian president and prime minister.

A variation on Madhubani art was launched in the early 1970s when a Harijani woman explained to her German visitor, Dr. Erika Moser, how she planned color for her drawings. She began by sticking small patches of various colored cloths onto paper to explain her color scheme. Realizing a potential market for “patchwork” cloth paintings, Moser encouraged the women to sew. This was not an easy task, since none of the women knew how. Unlike their counterparts in Bombay, Delhi, or Calcutta, who wear blouses or even tailored clothes, the women of this region use a simple cloth eight yards long and one yard wide to cover their entire body. Both men and women wear clothes until they are ragged, at which time they are replaced. But today many have mastered the art of fine stitchery, and “patchwork” Madhubani art has become an important handicraft trade of the region. The women of Jitwarpur have found a way to market their traditional designs and add income to their community. However, they still decorate their mud huts with cow-dung smears, and it is there that the intricacy and richness of their natural talents are best displayed. ●

NOTES

1. See *Encyclopaedia of Religion and Ethics*, 6 (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1959), 686; A. L. Basham, *The Wonder That Was India* (London: Sedgewick and Jackson, 1954), 40; J. Eggeling, *The Satapatha-Brahmana*, 1 (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1900), 216-18, vol. 5, 12-14.
2. This is the description in the *Ramayana* as given in its Tamil version by the poet Kampan.
3. The quotes and observations for this article were made during my visit to the village in the winter of 1984. Few scholars have been able to study these works because of the reluctance of the women to open their homes to foreigners. Since I am a Hindu and was accompanied by my mother, the women welcomed me.
4. Louis Renou, ed., *Hinduism* (New York: Washington Square Press, 1963), 61.

Jagdish J. Chavda, Professor of Art at the University of Central Florida, Orlando, teaches Asian art history and is a graphic designer.

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Jagdamda Devi, *The Goddess Kali* (c. 1980), detail of handwoven carpet using vegetable dyes.